

Real-Time 3D SPH Fluid Simulation with Marching-Cubes Surface Reconstruction in WebGPU

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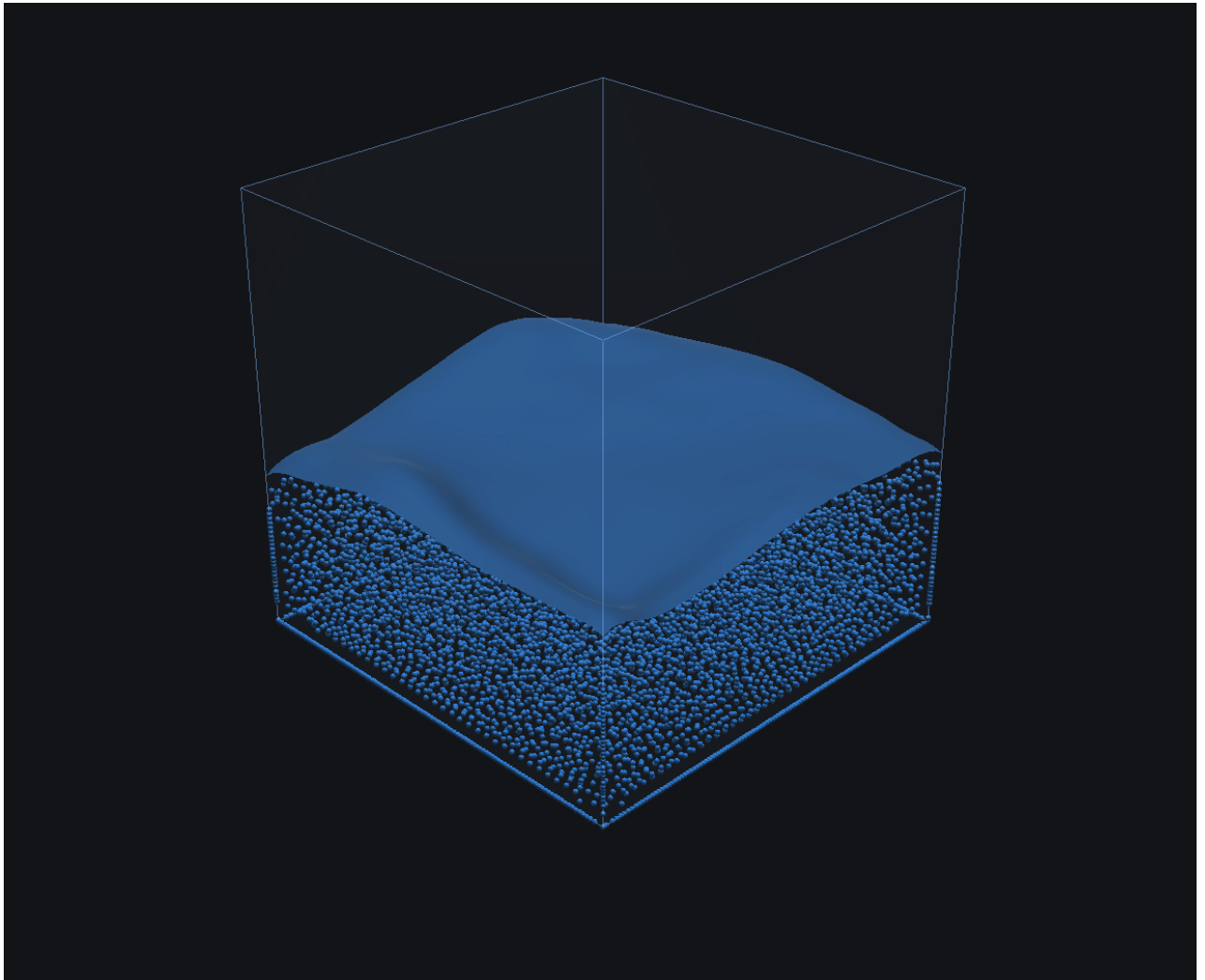


Figure 1: Pouring scenario at 10k particles, rendered simultaneously as point sprites (bulk fluid) and as a marching-cubes iso-surface of the SPH density field (smooth dome). The whole pipeline — neighbour search, SPH stages, density-field generation and marching-cubes extraction — runs on the GPU through WebGPU compute shaders.

Abstract

This report describes a real-time 3D fluid simulator built around weakly compressible smoothed-particle hydrodynamics (WCSPH) and marching-cubes surface reconstruction. The solver, the neighbour search and the iso-surface extraction all run on the GPU through the WebGPU compute API, with a small CPU JavaScript SPH reference kept as an oracle for validation. The simulation reproduces the kernels and equation of state of [MCG03], accelerates neighbour search with a uniform spatial hash and a bitonic key sort, and renders the fluid either as point sprites or as a triangulated iso-surface generated each frame by a multi-pass marching-cubes pipeline (field build, classify, prefix scan, emit). The implementation runs in the browser, scales to roughly 10^4 particles in real time on commodity hardware, and was cross-validated against the CPU reference: bulk density agrees within $\sim 1\%$ over a 600-step run despite parallel-reduction-induced per-particle drift. We discuss the wall-handling heuristic that suppresses the SPH kernel-deficiency artefact near the boundary, the parameter sensitivity of WCSPH, and the realism ceiling of the explicit solver.

CCS Concepts

•Computing methodologies → Physical simulation; Rendering; Mesh geometry models;

1. Introduction

Fluid simulation is one of the recurring set-pieces of computer graphics: it shows up in offline VFX, interactive games and engineering visualisations, and it is hard for the same reason in all three settings — the Navier–Stokes equations are non-linear, intrinsically multi-scale, and produce qualitatively different behaviour depending on how their constraints (incompressibility, viscosity, boundary conditions) are discretised.

Smoothed-particle hydrodynamics (SPH) is a Lagrangian discretisation of the governing equations: the fluid is represented as a set of moving particles, each carrying mass and physical quantities such as velocity, density and pressure. Field quantities at any point in space are recovered by convolving the particle data with a smoothing kernel [Mon92]. Because particles *are* the fluid, mass is trivially conserved, free surfaces appear without any front-tracking, and the simulation domain does not need a global grid. The trade-off is that pressure, viscosity and surface terms must all be expressed as kernel sums over neighbours, and that the time step is limited by the speed at which information propagates through the particle set (the CFL condition on the SPH sound speed).

The seminar topic is exactly this method, in 3D, with surface reconstruction by marching cubes for visualisation. Concretely, we were asked to:

- implement a basic SPH solver covering density estimation, pressure, viscosity and gravity;
- render the resulting fluid using a surface-reconstruction algorithm (marching cubes was the suggested choice);
- evaluate the resulting system with respect to particle count, initial conditions and parameter choices.

The contribution of this seminar is a complete working implementation that runs in a browser via WebGPU, including: a weakly compressible SPH solver with poly6 / spiky / viscosity kernels and the Tait equation of state [MCG03, IOS*14]; a uniform spatial hash with a bitonic key sort for $O(N \cdot \bar{k})$ neighbour queries [HKK07]; a fully GPU-resident marching-cubes pipeline [LC87] that scans the iso-surface contribution per voxel and emits a compacted triangle mesh; and a CPU JavaScript SPH reference used as a numerical oracle. The whole pipeline reaches interactive frame rates for $\sim 10^4$

particles on commodity hardware and was used to generate the figures throughout this report.

The remainder of this report is organised as follows. Section 2 reviews the WCSPH formulation we implemented and the marching-cubes surface extraction. Section 3 describes the GPU pipeline, the data layout, the neighbour search and the surface stage. Section 4 reports CPU/GPU parity, visual results and parameter sensitivity. Section 5 discusses the limitations of the explicit solver and Section 6 concludes.

2. Background

2.1. SPH formulation

In SPH, any continuous field $A(\mathbf{x})$ is reconstructed from the values A_j carried by neighbouring particles j at positions $\mathbf{x}_j$, weighted by a smoothing kernel $W(\mathbf{r}, h)$ of compact support h (the *smoothing radius*) [Mon92]:

$$A(\mathbf{x}) \approx \sum_j \frac{m_j}{\rho_j} A_j W(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_j, h). \quad (1)$$

The density is recovered as the special case $A_j = \rho_j$, which collapses (1) to

$$\rho_i = \sum_j m_j W(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j, h). \quad (2)$$

Following Müller et al. [MCG03], we use three distinct kernels for different terms: the smooth C^2 poly6 kernel for density,

$$W_{\text{poly6}}(r, h) = \frac{315}{64\pi h^9} (h^2 - r^2)^3, \quad 0 \leq r \leq h, \quad (3)$$

the *spiky* kernel whose gradient is non-zero at $r = 0$, for the pressure term,

$$\nabla W_{\text{spiky}}(r, h) = -\frac{45}{\pi h^6} (h - r)^2 \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \quad (4)$$

and the viscosity kernel whose Laplacian is strictly positive in $[0, h]$, for the viscous diffusion of velocity,

$$\nabla^2 W_{\text{visc}}(r, h) = \frac{45}{\pi h^6} (h - r). \quad (5)$$

Pressure is closed by the *Tait equation of state*, which makes the fluid *weakly compressible* (WCSPH):

$$p_i = k \left[\left(\frac{\rho_i}{\rho_0} \right)^\gamma - 1 \right], \quad \gamma = 7, \quad (6)$$

where ρ_0 is the rest density and k controls the stiffness of the response. Using a stiffness much lower than that of real water keeps the time step manageable at the price of a few-percent compressibility, which is the standard WCSPH trade-off [IOS*14].

The momentum equation discretised in SPH form, including a symmetrised pressure term and Müller-style viscosity, becomes:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{a}_i = & - \sum_j m_j \frac{p_i + p_j}{2\rho_j} \nabla W_{\text{spiky}}(\mathbf{r}_{ij}, h) \\ & + \mu \sum_j m_j \frac{\mathbf{v}_j - \mathbf{v}_i}{\rho_j} \nabla^2 W_{\text{visc}}(\mathbf{r}_{ij}, h) + \mathbf{g}. \end{aligned} \quad (7)$$

We then integrate with symplectic Euler: $\mathbf{v}_i \leftarrow \mathbf{v}_i + \Delta t \mathbf{a}_i$ followed by $\mathbf{x}_i \leftarrow \mathbf{x}_i + \Delta t \mathbf{v}_i$, substepped to stay below the CFL bound dictated by the SPH sound speed $c = \sqrt{k\gamma/\rho_0}$.

2.2. Neighbour search

A naive evaluation of (2) and (7) is $O(N^2)$, which is prohibitive for any reasonable particle count. SPH neighbour searches universally bin particles into a uniform grid of cell size h , then look up only the 27 cells of the local 3D neighbourhood [IOS*14, HKK07]. On GPU the canonical implementation is the *spatial-hash sort*: each particle emits a (cell, index) key, the keys are sorted by cell, and a separate pass fills a per-cell (start, end) table so that the SPH kernels only loop over a small, dense slice of particles.

2.3. Surface reconstruction by marching cubes

For visualisation, the particle cloud has to be turned into a surface. The standard SPH choice is to splat each particle into a regular 3D scalar field $\phi(\mathbf{x})$ using the same poly6 kernel, then extract an iso-surface at a level $\phi = \phi_{\text{iso}}$ (typically $0.5\rho_0$, which corresponds to the centre of the kernel-smoothing band of the surface particles). The iso-surface is meshed by the classical *marching-cubes* algorithm [LC87], which classifies each voxel of the field into one of 256 topological cases (based on which corners exceed the iso value) and emits zero to five triangles per voxel using a 256-entry lookup table. The result is a triangle mesh that can be rasterised by a standard shaded pass.

3. Implementation

3.1. Stack and architecture

The simulation is written in TypeScript and runs in a modern browser via the WebGPU API. All compute kernels are written in WGSL. The user interface uses Tweakpane for live parameter editing and stats.js for the FPS counter. The full pipeline is laid out as a set of GPU compute passes orchestrated from a small host-side wrapper, plus two render passes (point sprites and triangulated iso-surface). A CPU JavaScript SPH solver lives next to the GPU one and is used exclusively as a numerical oracle for validation.

Figure 2 summarises the per-frame pipeline.

sim.step

1. Hash particles into spatial-hash entries
2. Bitonic sort entries by cell id
3. Clear and build cellStart/cellEnd table
4. **Density + pressure** (poly6, Tait EOS)
5. **Forces** (spiky gradient + viscosity + gravity)
6. **Integrate** + boundary handling

surface.update

7. Field build (poly6 splat into 3D grid)
8. MC classify (8-corner case index + tri count)
9. Prefix scan (block-wise scan of triangle counts)
10. Write indirect draw args
11. MC emit (interpolated vertices + gradient normals)

renderer.draw

12. Box wireframe
13. Point sprites and/or triangulated iso-surface

Figure 2: Per-frame GPU compute and render pipeline. Steps 1–6 are the SPH solver, 7–11 the marching-cubes surface reconstruction, 12–13 the rendering. All compute passes are encoded into a single command buffer per frame.

3.2. Particle storage

Each particle is a 64-byte struct in a single GPU storage buffer:

```
position : vec3<f32>, _pad,
velocity : vec3<f32>, _pad,
acceleration : vec3<f32>, _pad,
density : f32, pressure : f32, _pad2.
```

The padding makes the natural 16-byte alignment of `vec3<f32>` in WGSL explicit, which removes a category of subtle layout bugs and keeps the struct shareable between every compute shader in the pipeline. The buffer is allocated for a fixed maximum particle count and resized only on explicit `sim.reset(N)`.

3.3. Spatial hash and bitonic sort

The spatial-hash pipeline mirrors the structure of [HKK07]. For each particle, the `hash.wgsl` pass writes a (`cellId`, `particleIndex`) pair into a key buffer (`hashEntriesA`). A bitonic sort then sorts these keys by `cellId` into `hashEntriesB` so that all particles in the same cell occupy a contiguous range. Finally, `cellTable.wgsl` scans the sorted array and writes per-cell (`start`, `end`) offsets into two N_{cells} -long arrays.

A bitonic sort was chosen over the more performant GPU radix sort because it is short (~100 lines of WGSL), self-contained, and easy to verify, while being more than fast enough at the target particle counts. Each bitonic stage is a pre-baked ($j, k, \text{mode}, N_{\text{pow2}}$) tuple. To get all stages to share one pipeline, we pack every stage into a single uniform buffer and select the active stage with a dynamic uniform offset (`setBindGroup(..., [offset])`). This avoids the trap that `queue.writeBuffer` between encoded passes is *not* sequenced by the GPU — all writes happen on the queue before the single `submit`, so a per-stage rewrite would give every stage the values of the *last* written stage. This and a related non-power-of-two padding bug, in which a real entry could

be paired with a sentinel from the virtual padding, were caught by a stand-alone sort unit test before integration with SPH.

3.4. Density, forces, integration

The three core SPH compute passes are direct translations of (2), (7) and symplectic Euler into WGSL. They all share the layout in Figure 2: a read-only neighbour bind group (`sortedEntries`, `cellStart`, `cellEnd`), a uniform buffer with the simulation parameters, and a read-write storage buffer for particles.

The `density.wgsl` pass loops over the 27 neighbouring cells of the current particle’s cell, fetches the dense particle range from `cellStart/cellEnd` for each cell, evaluates the poly6 kernel, accumulates ρ_i , computes the Tait pressure (6), and clamps to a configurable $p_{\max}$ to avoid explosions on transient compression spikes. The `forces.wgsl` pass uses the same 27-cell traversal to evaluate both pressure (with the symmetric gradient form $p_{ij} = (p_i + p_j)/(2\rho_j)$) and viscosity, then adds gravity scaled by density to match the Müller momentum convention. The result is stored as the particle’s acceleration. The `integrate.wgsl` pass advances velocity then position, applies the wall handling described in the next subsection, and runs at a substepped inner time step bounded by $\Delta t \leq 1/480s$ to stay below the CFL bound at $h = 0.075\text{ m}$ and $k = 1500$.

3.5. Boundary handling

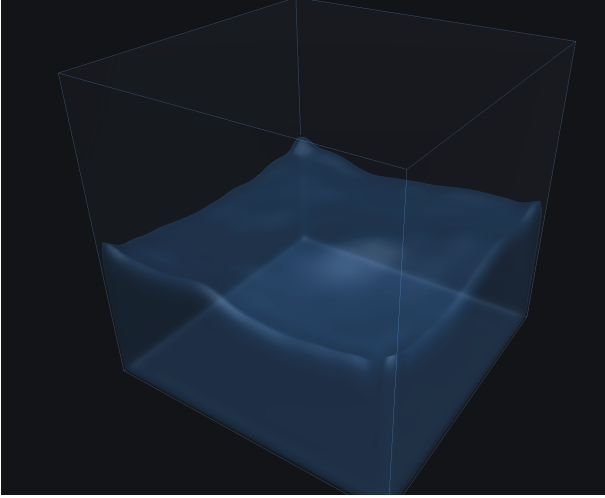


Figure 3: A settled fluid inside the simulation box. The flat top and corner curvature show that the soft repulsion band suppresses the kernel-deficiency tongues described in §3.5 without over-damping the bulk.

A plain reflective box wall is not enough in SPH: a particle pressed against a wall sums its density over a sphere that is only half-filled with fluid neighbours (the other half is outside the wall), under-reports ρ , under-shoots p through (6), and is therefore pushed harder *into* the wall by bulk pressure than it can push back. With reflection only, this manifests as a thin sheet of fluid “climbing” the box — the classical kernel-deficit artefact [IOS*14].

The proper fix is ghost particles or boundary particles; the cheap fix that works for visual purposes is a Monaghan-style soft repulsion band. Within a band of width $\eta \cdot h$ of any wall (we use $\eta = 0.7$), an outward acceleration $a = Kt^2$ is added, where $t \in [0, 1]$ ramps from 0 at the band edge to 1 at the wall and K is the repulsion strength. To stop the band from acting like a purely conservative spring (which would make particles bounce springily off every wall), a velocity-normal damping $a' = -cv_n t$ is also applied, but only when the velocity component points *into* the wall, so it can never trap a particle. The reflective wall is then kept as a hard back-stop for the rare cases where a particle still tunnels (e.g. at high impact velocities). Figure 3 shows the resulting steady state.

3.6. Marching-cubes surface reconstruction on GPU

The marching-cubes implementation runs entirely on the GPU as a sequence of seven compute passes that we orchestrate from `surface/index.ts`:

Field build. The `fieldBuild.wgsl` pass dispatches one thread per grid vertex of an $n_x \times n_y \times n_z$ scalar field, with each thread looping over the active particles and accumulating their poly6 contribution at its sample position. We chose the gather direction (thread-per-voxel) over the scatter direction (thread-per-particle) so the field-build pass needs no atomics. Voxels that lie outside the simulation box are clamped to $\phi = 0$, which lets marching cubes close the iso-surface flush against the glass. A small bit-twiddle test discards NaN/Inf samples in case a single bad particle slips in.

Classify. `mcClassify.wgsl` reads the eight corners of each voxel, compares each against the iso value to build the 8-bit case index, and writes `cubeCase` and `cubeTriCount` (the latter fetched from a 256-entry `numTrisTable` uploaded once at startup).

Compaction by exclusive prefix scan. The lookup table tells us how many triangles each voxel emits, so the write offset for voxel i in the output vertex buffer is the *exclusive prefix sum* of triangle counts up to i . We compute this scan on GPU via a Belloch-style multi-level pass: a `scanLocal` pass scans blocks of 256 elements and writes per-block sums; a `scanBlockSums` pass scans the block sums (recursively when needed); a `scanAddOffsets` pass adds the block-level offsets back into the per-block prefixes. This part of the pipeline does not depend on the field — it is a generic GPU-compaction primitive and was written and tested against random synthetic inputs before being plugged into the rest of the surface pipeline.

Indirect draw arguments. A tiny `computeDrawMeta.wgsl` pass reads the very last entries of the prefix and tri-count buffers, computes the total triangle count, clamps to the safety cap `maxTriangles`, and writes the four-word `drawIndirect` arguments directly into a `GPUBuffer` bound for indirect drawing. This means the CPU never needs to know how many triangles the GPU produced — the draw call uses `drawIndirect`, which keeps the round-trip latency out of the frame loop.

Emit. `mcEmit.wgsl` reads each voxel’s case index and its prefix offset, looks up the per-case triangle table, interpolates vertex positions along the cube edges where the field crosses the iso value, and computes per-vertex normals from central differences of the scalar field. Outputs are written to the positions/normals storage buffers at the offsets reserved by the scan.

Render. The mesh is rasterised by `render/surfaceMesh.ts`, which uses `drawIndirect` on the buffer written in the previous step, applies a Phong + Fresnel shader with a fixed light direction and a cheap fake refraction colour, and blends the result over either an empty scene or the point-sprite render of the underlying particles. The renderer exposes three modes (*points*, *surface*, *both*) so the same scene can be inspected in either representation; this is also useful for debugging the surface pipeline against the particles it is supposed to fit (Figure 4).

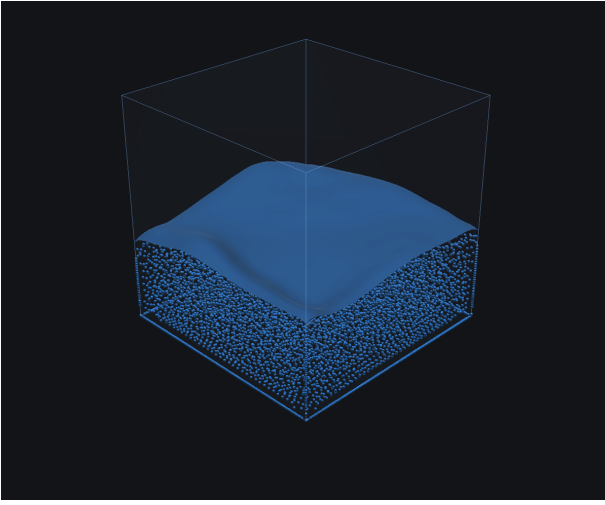


Figure 4: both *render mode*: the same scene with point sprites and the marching-cubes surface drawn simultaneously. Useful for verifying that the iso-surface actually hugs the particle cloud rather than drifting or ringing inside it.

3.7. Validation and parity harness

For validation we built a CPU JavaScript SPH solver with the same kernels, EOS and integrator. It deliberately mirrors the GPU code path field for field, so that a divergence in behaviour is almost always caused by GPU-specific issues (parameter packing, sort bugs, atomic ordering) rather than by physics differences. A parity harness in `src/app.ts` clones the CPU dam-break scenario onto the GPU, runs both sides at lockstep $\Delta t = 1/240$ s for 600 steps, and reads back the GPU buffer every 30 steps to compare $\min/\text{avg}/\max \rho$, $|\mathbf{v}|_{\max}$, KE and $|\mathbf{p}|$ against tolerance bands.

4. Results

4.1. CPU/GPU numerical parity

After aligning the two solvers (matching CFL substep cap, disabling the GPU’s wall band on both sides, and matching boundary

tangent damping) the bulk density agrees to better than 1.1 % over the whole 600-step run, and all metrics agree to better than 2.6 % in the validation window (steps 30–90, where the system is still flowing and meaningful per-particle quantities can be compared). After $\sim$ step 100 the per-particle metrics begin to drift by tens of percent, but the macroscopic state (the density distribution, the total kinetic energy envelope) continues to track. This is not a correctness bug — it is parallel-reduction-order chaos: the CPU sums in sequential order while the GPU does tree reductions, and the sub-ULP differences are amplified by the chaotic dynamics of an equilibrium fluid. The same effect appears in published GPU SPH parity studies and is what motivates statistical, not bit-exact, validation [IOS*14]. For the seminar’s purpose, the GPU SPH math — density, pressure, viscosity, integration — is validated against the CPU oracle.

4.2. Visual results across scenarios

Figure 1 (front page) shows the system at the target operating point: a ~ 10 k-particle pour stream impacting a pool and rendered with both representations. Figure 5 zooms in on the impact at mid-fill, where the marching-cubes surface hugs the splash dome while individual stray particles remain visible above. Figure 6 shows the same scenario with a static obstacle (rendered separately as an SDF in the surface shader), which produces a recognisable rim of fluid trapped against the obstacle base.

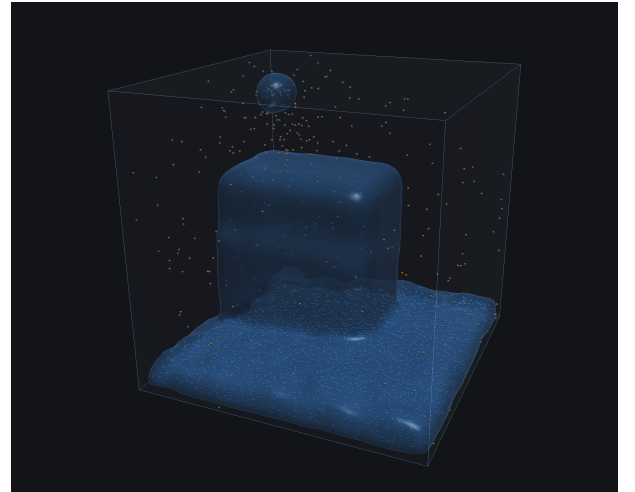


Figure 5: Mid-fill of the pouring scenario. A continuous SPH stream is released from a 4×4 puck emitter at the top of the box and impacts the accumulating pool. The marching-cubes surface (smooth) captures the splash dome; stray particles outside the iso-level remain visible.

4.3. Parameter sensitivity

The two parameters with the most visible effect on the look of the fluid are the viscosity coefficient μ and the marching-cubes iso value ϕ_{iso} . At low μ (Figure 7) the splash on impact becomes visibly more energetic and individual droplets separate from the bulk,



Figure 6: Pour scenario with a static obstacle. The stream wraps around the obstacle and accumulates as a rim, the typical behaviour of an incompressible fluid running over a convex body.

which is closer to real water but also closer to the stability boundary of the explicit solver: lowering μ much further leads to velocity spikes that get clamped by $p_{\max}$. At high μ the fluid takes on a syrupy, smoothed-out look in which splashes are visibly underdamped.

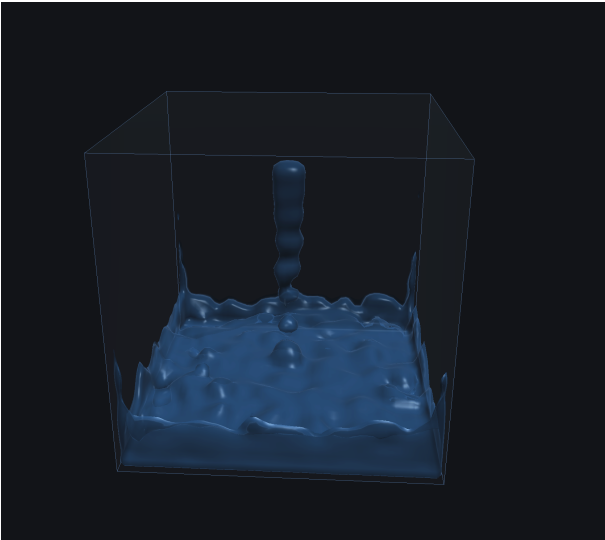


Figure 7: Low-viscosity pour ($\mu = 1.0$): the impact produces a clean central jet and rim of small droplets, visually closer to water. The trade-off is reduced stability margin.

The iso value controls where in the kernel-smoothing band the surface sits. At $\phi_{\text{iso}} \approx 0.5\rho_0$ the surface is the visually clean “halfway through the band” choice recommended by [MCG03];

lowering it below $\sim 0.3\rho_0$ produces a puffy, blocky surface that picks up the outer halo of the kernel; raising it past ρ_0 disconnects the surface into beads of fluid where the bulk doesn’t quite reach full rest density.

A failure mode worth documenting is what happens when the timestep, viscosity and gas constant fall out of the WCSPH stability triangle: the simulation explodes within milliseconds (Figure 8). The maximum-pressure clamp catches most cases, but a too-stiff k at a too-large Δt will always win against any clamp. The defaults in the released demo were tuned by bisecting around the recommended values from [MCG03] until a 30-second pour remained visually plausible.

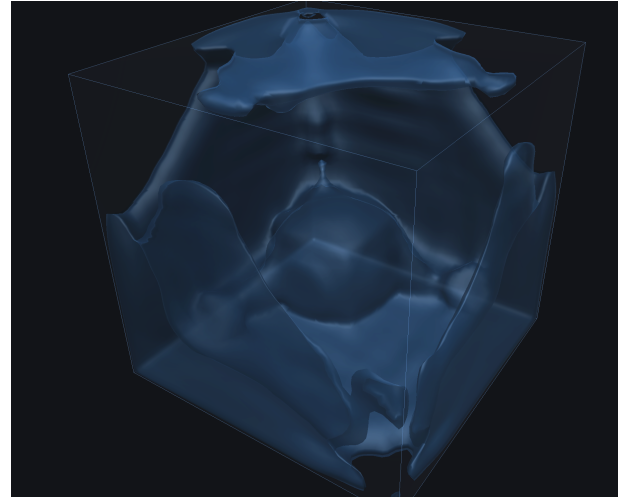


Figure 8: Catastrophic failure: a too-large timestep ($\Delta t = 1/60s$, no substep cap) combined with the production stiffness gives a snapshot where the SPH sound speed has been exceeded and the iso-surface is being violently re-meshed every frame. Included to motivate the substep cap and pressure clamp.

4.4. Scaling and performance notes

The pipeline as implemented reaches interactive frame rates for $\sim 10k$ particles on a commodity laptop GPU. The dominant costs are, in decreasing order: the field-build pass (it is $O(N_{\text{voxels}} \cdot N_{\text{particles}})$ in its current gather form), the density and forces passes (now reduced to $O(N \cdot \bar{k})$ with $\bar{k} \approx 35$ thanks to the spatial hash), and the bitonic sort (which is $O(N \log^2 N)$ but on small key sizes). Lifting the field-build cost would either route its sampling through the same spatial-hash table as the SPH passes, or switch to a particle-scatter implementation with atomics; both are listed as deferred work in the project’s planning notes and are not required for the seminar deliverable. The marching-cubes scan and emit passes scale linearly in the number of voxels and have not been the bottleneck at the grid resolutions tested (up to 64^3).

5. Discussion

The implementation hits the seminar target — a runnable, interactive 3D SPH solver with a marching-cubes surface — but several

limitations are worth calling out, both because they shape the visual result and because they are interesting in their own right.

WCSPH compressibility. The Tait EOS allows a small amount of compression ($\sim 1\%$ in practice), which manifests as a faint “breathing” of the surface under load. Truly incompressible behaviour requires either a much larger stiffness k (and a proportionally smaller Δt) or a switch to one of the predictive-corrective family of solvers (PCISPH, IISPH, PBF) that add a pressure-correction loop inside each step [IOS*14]. We intentionally stayed with WCSPH because the brief asked for a basic SPH solver, and because the corrective schemes meaningfully complicate the GPU implementation.

Boundary handling. The soft band described in §3.5 is an ad-hoc fix for the kernel deficit at walls, and is the most visible source of non-physical behaviour. The principled fix is to seed a layer of boundary particles or ghost particles that mirror the fluid across each wall; with those in place the density at the wall is correctly computed and the bulk pressure stops driving particles into the boundary. We did not implement this because the band-aid is good enough for the seminar’s visual quality and stability targets, and because ghost particles interact awkwardly with the spatial-hash neighbour table.

Surface tension and droplet realism. WCSPH has no cohesion term, so the surface tension that holds droplets together in real fluids is absent here. Detached fluid does form droplet-shaped iso-surfaces because of the kernel-smoothing radius, but the droplet behaviour is purely a consequence of mass and pressure, not surface energy. The standard remedy is Müller’s follow-up cohesion force on a colour field, which we did not implement.

Surface aliasing at moderate grid resolutions. At grid resolutions below $\sim 48^3$ the marching-cubes surface shows visible step-shading artefacts where neighbouring voxels share field values that straddle the iso threshold differently. Raising the grid resolution to 64^3 removes most of them at the cost of an N^3 increase in field-build work; doubling the resolution is roughly the largest step the current field-build pass can absorb without dropping below interactive rates.

6. Conclusion

This seminar implemented a 3D SPH fluid simulator with marching-cubes surface reconstruction, runnable in a browser via WebGPU. The solver follows the WCSPH formulation of Müller et al. [MCG03], the neighbour search uses a uniform spatial hash with a bitonic key sort following Harada et al. [HKK07], and the surface stage runs the full marching-cubes pipeline of Lorensen & Cline [LC87] on the GPU as a sequence of seven compute passes ending with an indirect-drawn triangulated mesh. The implementation was cross-validated against a CPU JavaScript reference solver, and the resulting demo reaches interactive frame rates for $\sim 10^4$ particles on commodity hardware.

The deliverable suggests several natural extensions for follow-up work: routing the marching-cubes field build through the existing spatial-hash table to lift the particle-count ceiling, adding implicit viscosity to bring μ closer to that of real water, and replacing

the soft-band boundary heuristic with proper boundary particles. These are deferred to a thesis-scope continuation of the project; the present report describes the seminar implementation as delivered.

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